



PERFECT LANDING Paintings and sculptures, once part of Air India's famed collection, being showcased at an ongoing exhibition; (left) an airplane sculpture at the entrance

tional Indian art," explains Patro. "The narrative highlights iconic and lesser-known artists, weaving traditional symbolism with modern experimentation." The result is a layered archive, showcasing the Progressive Artists' Group—Raza, Souza, Ara—alongside miniature paintings, Thanjavur glass works, antique bronzes, Kalamkari textiles, lithographs and Lala Deen Dayal's studio photography. This fusion of tradition and modernity lies at the heart of *Sanhitha*.

The visitor experience is immersive. The NGMA heritage building is reimagined with a colour palette inspired by vintage Air India motifs. Architectural elements like *jharokhas*—Mughal-style balconies—serve as storytelling devices, while two airplane sculptures at the entrance and exit frame the journey: one symbolising history, the other legacy. "The key was to reflect Air India's evolving identity while also resonating with broader cultural trends," says Darshan.

The exhibition unfolds like a travelogue: Salvador Dalí's surreal 'Ashtray' (famously traded for a baby elephant), Mario Miranda's office-themed illustrations, and quirky memorabilia such as coasters, postcards and storybooks. A mid-century 'smoking lounge' vignette captures the glamour of early air travel.

The show pays homage to modern masters—Husain, Prabha, B. Vithal—while also spotlighting women artists like Kanchan Chandra, Anjolie Ela Menon, Arpana Caur and Pilloo Pochkhanawala. Regional movements such as the Madras Art Movement (Vasudeva, Bhaskaran) appear alongside folk metal sculptures, Gaitonde's abstractions, and Sakti Burman's layered prints. The message is clear: Indian art is a diverse confluence, not a monolith.

Curated by Subarna Patro and Darshan Kumar YU, this show is far more than a retrospective—it is a cultural reckoning

In an age of fleeting attention and fractured narratives, this exhibition invites us to pause and look back—not with nostalgia, but with clarity and pride. It reminds us that art is not merely decorative, but profoundly political and powerfully personal. And it honours an airline whose wings carried more than passengers—they carried a nation's imagination. ■

–Nikhil Sardana

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the contemporary Tamil poet Muthu Kumara Raja." Through this lens, the exhibition traces Tamil identity in its layered, diasporic and politically charged complexity.

Rejecting simplified or singular narratives, the exhibition embraces multiplicity—of experience, memory and emotion. Visitors encounter deeply personal visual languages that explore queer desire, kinship, migration, grief, trauma and healing. "Tamil identity is so layered—it can't be captured through one image, or one artist," notes Nageswaran. "That's why I chose 12 different voices for this show. Together, they form a kind of collective portrait—one that's still in flux."

FEATURING 12 TAMIL-ORIGIN ARTISTS, THE EXHIBITION WILL BE ON DISPLAY AT THE MUSEUM OF ART & PHOTOGRAPHY, BENGALURU, FROM APRIL 19 TO JULY 20

The line-up includes Aishwarya Arumbakkam, whose practice spans photography, filmmaking and drawing; Alina Tiphagne, whose assemblages of text and image explore familial and queer histories; and Arun Karthick, whose acclaimed film *Nasir* brought Tamil life to global screens. Artists like Brindha Anantharaman and Osheen Siva engage with gender, mental health and Dalit futurism, while others such as Krithika Sriram and Priyadarshini Ravichandran explore identity politics and the feminine relationship to land.

Nageswaran's curatorial approach is grounded in his own background growing up in Madurai and years of documenting personal and familial histories. "From the beginning, I didn't want this to be a show of only photo prints—I envisioned something more layered, a curatorial framework that reflects multiplicity," he says of the exhibition which is a collaborative project by the Goethe-Institut Chennai and the Chennai Photo Biennale.

In inviting viewers to contemplate identity, and belonging, the show offers both a mirror and a window—rooted in Tamil experience yet expansive in its reach. ■

–Nikhil Sardana